Narrative's Influence: The Clinton Administration's Decision to Act in the Bosnian War

Introduction

The Bosnian War, which started in 1992 after the secession of Bosnia from Yugoslavia, quickly evolved into one of the greatest humanitarian crises of the late 20th century. The Bosnian Serb army committed massive human rights violations against the two other major ethnic groups in Bosnia, the Bosnian Croats and the Bosnian Muslims, including war crimes such as rape, genocide, and forced resettlement. Though U.S. President Bill Clinton campaigned on an aggressive policy for Bosnia that supported military intervention, his presidential policy was much different. Faced with opposition from allies and Congress, he switched to a "muddle through" strategy, hoping half-measures of diplomacy and humanitarian aid would keep Bosnia out of the domestic spotlight and allow him to focus on his domestic agenda.

Nevertheless, after the Srebrenica Genocide on July 11, 1995, in which the Bosnian Serb Army killed over 8,000 Muslim men, the administration suddenly shifted to a highly successful policy that resulted in the signing of a peace agreement within a few months. The reason for this shift has been hotly debated among scholars. Many arguments have been put forth about the primary reason, though most writers agree on five main factors: Anthony Lake's newfound strength, French President Chirac's demand that the U.S. do more, Congress' passing of a lift and strike bill the administration opposed, the new offensive of the Bosnian Serb army, and the upcoming U.S. presidential election.

However, I contend that the Srebrenica Genocide was only the most visible turning point of the administration's policy. Instead, I argue that since 1993 the administration had been experiencing a shift in its internal narrative of the Bosnian War, a shift from viewing the war as just another ethnic conflict to one of violent, concentrated aggression perpetrated by the Bosnian

Serbs. As a result of this narrative shift, the doxa of options—the options that the administration even considered—changed from an everything-goes approach to a highly focused approach targeting the protection of Goražde with air strikes.

To support my argument, I use declassified documents from several departments and bureaucracies within the Clinton Administration, including the National Security Council, the Department of State, and the Department of Defense, covering the year 1993 and 1995. Given that I am opposing the literature's focus on the Srebrenica Genocide as the turning point for the administration, I have chosen to not discuss the narrative and doxa from 1994, to make the development of the administration's narrative from its inception to its intervention as clear as possible.

The Bosnian War

Origins of Ethnic Identity in the Balkans

To understand the origins of the Bosnian War, one must return to the Ottoman Empire and the beginnings of group identity in the Balkans. The Ottoman Empire began conquering the Balkans in the late 14th century and ruled the territory, which included most of the former Yugoslavia, from the 1500s until it slowly began to collapse at the start of the 19th century. This long period of rule left a massive mark on people's conceptualizations of identity. Under the Ottoman Empire, citizens were divided based on religion, with only Muslims having full rights but Jewish and Chirstian denizens being protected by law. As a result of this strict legal division by religion, religious identity was the single most important marker for individuals under the Ottoman Empire.[1] Furthermore, Orthodox Christian identity was particularly strong, with

[1] Raymond Detrez, "Pre-National Identities in the Balkans," in *Entangled Histories of the Balkans*, ed. Roumen Dontchev Daskalov and Tchavdar Marinov (Brill, 2013), 24, https://brill.com/display/title/18798.

Orthodox Christians under the Ottoman Empire considering themselves part of the Romaic community.[2]

However, starting in the 18th century, a new model of identity began to challenge this religion-based system. Romantic nationalism, which advocated for a group identity based on the culture and history of that specific group, as well as emotional connections to these two things, quickly became highly influential in the Balkans.[3] Johann Gottfried Herder's version of Romantic nationalism in particular had a large effect on national identity thought in the Balkans. Herder called on Germans to oppose the tendency towards a cosmopolitan identity and study German-language folk poetry as a way to return to their original German identity, emphasizing that the "language of fathers" is the core of a national identity.[4] Many intellectuals in the Balkans answered Herder's call, traveling the region to collect and publish poetry from blind folk singers; thus, a language-based identity quickly garnered popularity among the elite.

Over the 19th and 20th centuries, these dueling foundations for national identity in the Balkans— religion and language—became enmeshed in complex ways. For example, in the Yugoslav censuses of 1953 and 1981, language and nationality did not perfectly coincide—some Macedonian speakers identified not as Macedonian but as Albanian, Serb, or Vlah, among others.[5] Furthermore, the nationalities themselves were highly varied, including Muslim, Yugoslav, and Turk.[6] Earlier, at the outbreak of the First World War, Bulgarian-, Greek-, and Serb-identifying writers were categorizing residents of the geographic area of Macedonia into

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[2] Detrez, "Pre-National," 26.
[3] Dennis P. Hupchick, *The Balkans from Constantinople to Communism* (New York: Palgrave, 2002), 189.
[4] William A. Wilson, *The Marrow of Human Experience: Essays on Folklore*, ed. Jill Terry Rudy and Diane Call (Logan, Utah: Utah State University Press, 2006), 114-5.
[5] Victor A. Friedman, "Populations and Powderkegs: The Macedonian Census of 1994 in Historical Perspective," *Occasional Papers*, no. 44: 20, https://www.wilsoncenter.org/sites/default/files/media/documents/publication/OP%2044.pdf.
[6] Friedman, "Populations," 20.

majority Bulgarian, Greek, or Serb depending on the writer's own identity, using different aspects of the residents' language to argue for the language's similarity to the writer's own, as well as the residents' religion.[7] At the same time, however, governments in the Balkans were strongly pushing to homogenize their populations, using population exchanges and forced assimilation into the majority language to achieve this goal.[8] At the end of the 20th century, then, the Balkans, and particularly Yugoslavia, was struggling to balance complicated national identities with the need for a homogenous population.

The Collapse of Yugoslavia

The Socialist Federal Republic of Yugoslavia was founded after the end of the Second World War, with Josip Broz Tito as its leader. Through a powerful control of his cult of personality, Tito managed to keep the identity tensions in check across the six republics that made up Yugoslavia—Bosnia and Herzegovina, Slovenia, Croatia, Serbia (with autonomous provinces Kosovo and Vojvodina), Montenegro, and Macedonia—for decades. However, Tito's death in 1980 destroyed this control and allowed one man to rise to power in Serbia's capital, Belgrade, the heart of political power in Yugoslavia: Slobodan Milošević.

Milošević garnered widespread public support in Serbia because of his Serb nationalist rhetoric. The Serb national myth revolves around the Battle of Kosovo, a 1389 battle in which the Kingdom of Serbia lost to the invading Ottoman forces, and which the myth describes in terms of religion, as a losing battle for the Serb Orthodox Christians against the Ottoman Muslims.[9] This myth, and this religious perspective, is immensely potent. As Olga Zirojević explains, "In the national consciousness of the Serbian people, the Battle of Kosovo was, and

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[7] Friedman, "Populations," 12.
[8] Mark Mazower, *The Balkans* (London: Weidenfeld & Nicolson, 2000), 106-7.
[9] Milne Holton and Vasa D. Mihailovich, *Songs of the Serbian People: From the Collections of Vuk Karadzic* (Pittsburgh: University of Pittsburgh Press, 1997), 134, 147.

still is, the central event in its entire history."[10] Consequently, Kosovo itself, and its majority Muslim population, was a sore spot for many nationalist Serbs, and one that was highly prominent during the 1980s, due to discontent among Serbs about how the Kosovo question had been handled under Tito.[11] Milošević took on the cause of the Serb minority in Kosovo and published a highly influential book on the topic, starting off his influence in Serbian politics; eventually, through a series of shrewd political maneuvers, he managed to become the President of the League of Communists of Serbia, bringing this cause along with him.[12] In the end, the communist party, with him at the head, became a Serb nationalist party, focused on uniting all the Orthodox Christian speakers of the Yugoslav language under one state.

At the same time as Serb nationalism was becoming the dominant ideology in Serbia, the other republics began to clamor for more autonomy from Belgrade. In 1990, Yugoslavia held its first multiparty elections, in which the communist party only won in Serbia and Montenegro.[13] Franjo Tudjman of Croatia and his party, the Croatian Democratic Alliance, led the demand for a confederation and began negotiating with Belgrade in 1991, but Tudjman had also revived Croat (Croats are Catholic) nationalism in Croatia, removing Serbs as a majority ethnic group from the constitution and adding ethnic Croat motifs to the Croatian republic symbols.[14] As a result, each side became more and more entrenched in its own nationalism, until June 1991, when both Croatia and Slovenia announced their secession from Yugoslavia.[15] The Yugoslav army (commanded from Belgrade by Milošević) invaded both republics in an effort to keep them in

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[10] Olga Zirojević, "Kosovo in the Collective Memory," in *The Road to War in Serbia: Trauma and Catharsis*, ed. Nebojša Popov (Budapest, Hungary: Central European University Press, 2000), 189.
[11] Aleksa Djilas, "A Profile of Slobodan Milosevic," *Foreign Affairs* 72, no. 3 (1993): 82, https://heinonline.org/HOL/Page?handle=hein.journals/fora72&div=52&g_sent=1&casa_token=&collection=journals#.
[12] Djilas, "A Portrait," 86-87.
[13] Lenard J. Cohen, "The Disintegration of Yugoslavia," *University of California Press* 91, no. 568 (1992): 371, https://www.jstor.org/stable/45316718.
[14] Cohen, "The Disintegration," 371-2.
[15] Cohen, "The Disintegration," 373.

Yugoslavia; the war in Slovenia lasted less than ten days, given that few Serbs lived in the region, while the one in Croatia, which had a substantial Serb population, dragged on.[16]

The War in Bosnia

Shortly after, in a referendum in February 1992, Bosnia and Herzegovina decided to secede as well. This was a disaster for Milošević and other Serb nationalists, as Bosnia contained vast numbers of Serbs, in addition to Muslims and Croats.[17] As a result, local Serb paramilitary groups and the Yugoslav army worked together to stop Bosnia's secession, quickly surrounding and besieging the capital in Sarajevo and mobilizing to take over ⅔ of Bosnia within six weeks of the secession announcement.[18] The international community placed an arms embargo on Bosnia, and war erupted between the Croat and Muslim armies as well, though this war was ended by a 1994 agreement.[19] The UN provided UNPROFOR, a small group of troops for the protection of humanitarian aid, as well as safe areas, and then the war descended into stalemate, until one of the major safe areas, Srebrenica, was overrun by the Bosnian Serb army in July 1995, leading to the murder of over 7,000 men.[20]

Soon after this genocide, NATO began airstrikes on Bosnian Serb positions, and the joint Muslim and Croat armies launched a land offensive, forcing the Bosnian Serbs to come to the negotiating table.[21] The war ended with the December 1995 Dayton Accords, in which a Bosnian Serb entity received 49% of Bosnia while remaining part of Bosnia.[22]

The Clinton Administration's Major Initiatives on Bosnia

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[16] Cohen, "The Disintegration," 373.
[17] Cohen, "The Disintegration," 375.
[18] Cohen, "The Disintegration," 374; John R. Lampe, "The Bosnian War," *Encyclopedia Britannica*, October 6, 2022, https://www.britannica.com/event/Bosnian-War.
[19] Lampe, "The Bosnian."
[20] Lampe, "The Bosnian."
[21] Lampe, "The Bosnian."
[22] Lampe, "The Bosnian."

Bill Clinton made Bosnia an important part of his 1992 presidential campaign. While the Bush administration did not want to get involved in Bosnia, preferring to let Europe lead, and characterized the war as a civil war, Clinton called the conflict a "war of aggression" and accused President Bush of supporting human rights abuses through his inaction.[23] Clinton called for UN Security Council air strikes and more sanctions against Milošević, as well as the use of force against Serbia and the lifting of the arms embargo on Bosnia.[24] Thus, he came into office with a very aggressive position on the Bosnian War.

However, this position quickly disintegrated. The military opposed intervention in Bosnia, and Clinton did not want a foreign war to impact his domestic agenda, so he accepted Secretary of State Warren Christopher's February 1993 policy proposal: containment of Bosnia with the administration only supporting sanctions and humanitarian aid to give the appearance of effort.[25] This policy, known as "muddle through," was the centerpiece of Bosnia policy from 1993 until July 1995.

During that time period, several ultimately useless initiatives started. The Vance-Owen Peace Plan (VOPP), drafted by UN and European Committee envoys in January 1993, divided Bosnia up into ethnic provinces and gave only 43% of land to Serbs, but the US rejected it, objecting to rewarding the Serbs with territory.[26] The Joint Action Plan, created by the US, Russia, Spain, France, and Great Britain on May 25, 1993, provided support for the protection of the UN Safe Areas and the creation of a war crimes tribunal, but few troops were committed for

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[23] Luca Trenta, "Clinton and Bosnia: A Candidate's Freebie, a President's Nightmare," *Journal of Transatlantic Studies* 12, no.1 (2014): 64-65, 68, https://doi.org/10.1080/14794012.2014.871434.
[24] Trenta, "Clinton," 65; Sébastien Barthe and Charles-Philippe David, "Foreign Policy-Making in the Clinton Administration: Reassessing Bosnia and the "Turning Point" of 1995," (paper presented at the International Studies Association Conference, Montréal, March 17-20 2004), 2-3, https://dandurand.uqam.ca/wp-content/uploads/2016/04/ERD_foreign_policy_making_Barthe.pdf.
[25] Trenta, "Clinton," 68; Barthe and David, "Foreign Policy-Making," 3.
[26] Trenta, "Clinton," 67.

the former.[27] In April of 1994, the US, Great Britain, and France established a Contact Group to coordinate peace efforts in Bosnia, but these allies still had a lot of friction among them.[28] Most troublingly was the UN-NATO "dual-key" on air strikes. This dual key, which required both the NATO Commander in Chief of Allied Forces South and the UNPROFOR commander to agree to air strikes, was a compromise between the US and Europe after the air strike option was initially proposed following strong violence in Sarajevo in July 1993, and continued to plague decision-making throughout the Bosnian War.[29]

Then came the fall of Srebrenica. From the 11th of July through the 13th, 1995, the Bosnian Serb army overran the UN Safe Area of Srebrenica and perpetuated massive war crimes.[30] The US suddenly took control of the situation, forcing the other powers in an emergency London meeting on July 14 to agree to air strikes against the Bosnian Serbs if they attacked Goražde, another safe area, and then extending the pressure to NATO allies on July 25, who also acquiesced.[31] This was an abrupt and complete shift from the policy of muddling through that the Clinton administration had practiced for over two years.

Why Did The Clinton Administration Change Its Bosnia Approach?

This shift has garnered much attention from scholars, who have identified five potential influences and argued for variable importance of each: National Security Advisor Anthony Lake, the situation change in Bosnia, the upcoming presidential election, French President Jacques Chirac's pressure, and Congressional pressure. However, three of these, Congressional pressure, Chirac pressure, and the upcoming presidential election, do not explain the shift thoroughly.

Congressional Pressure

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[27] Trenta, "Clinton," 72.
[28] Trenta, "Clinton," 75-6.
[29] Trenta, "Clinton," 73.
[30] Trenta, "Clinton," 80.
[31] Trenta, "Clinton," 82.

Supporters of the Congressional pressure argument point to two bills lifting the arms embargo, one in the House that passed on June 8, 1995, and one in the Senate that passed on July 25, as the instigator for the Clinton Administration to act.[32] They argue that the bills were a direct threat to the Clinton Administration because they not only represented a loss of control of foreign policy for the administration, but, more worryingly, could potentially invoke a commitment of US troops.[33] Clinton had, during a crisis with NATO over air strikes in November of 1994, promised to use 25,000 U.S. troops to protect UNPROFOR troops during their withdrawal should they choose to do so.[34] The lifting of the arms embargo could incite UNPROFOR to withdraw and trigger this troop commitment, which would be disastrous for an administration wanting to stay focused on its domestic policy. Thus, the administration had to show it could take decisive action after the Srebrenica Genocide, or risk a complete loss of support for its position.

These two bills, and their consequences, heavily concerned policymakers in the Clinton administration after the Srebrenica Genocide. On July 11 and 12, 1995, the deputies of the major U.S. government departments met to discuss responses to the Srebrenica Genocide. In a memorandum on the meeting for National Security Advisor Anthony Lake from Director of European Affairs for the National Security Council (NSC) Nelson Drew on July 12th, 1995, Drew wrote that the deputies "agreed that efforts to stabilize the situation will be critical to our efforts to avoid Congressional action on unilateral lift."[35] In his July 12th Bosnia Strategy Paper for Lake, Alexander Vershbow, Senior Director for European Affairs at the National Security

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[32] Barthe and David, "Foreign Policy-Making," 8.
[33] Trenta, "Clinton," 79; Barthe and David, "Foreign Policy-Making," 8.
[34] Trenta, "Clinton," 77.
[35] Nelson Drew, "Memorandum for Anthony Lake," in *Declassified Documents Concerning Genocide in the Former Yugoslavia*, 2013-0656-M, Clinton Digital Library, July 12, 1995, 237, https://clinton.presidentiallibraries.us/items/show/101193.

Council, explained that failing to push back against Bosnian Serb advances would "guarantee passage of unilateral lift legislation by the Congress in a manner that will damage relations with our allies."[36] In an options paper for the protection of Goražde on July 17th, Jim Pardew argues that "UNPROFOR must show some resolve immediately or unilateral lift is going to happen. Without an UNPROFOR commitment to act firmly quickly, fall-back strategies, including Sarajevo, won't work either and won't prevent a US unilateral lift law."[37] Officials in the Clinton Administration were urgently looking for some way to respond to the genocide to ensure that they were still able to push back against Congressional legislation on lifting the arms embargo.

However, policymakers were concerned about these bills even before the Srebrenica Genocide. On July 10th, Vershbow wrote in a strategy paper on Bosnia that an important facet of the administration's strategy should be "working with Dole [sponsor of the Senate bill] and other key Congressional leaders to ensure that language in any unilateral lift resolution provides leverage in negotiations before being triggered."[38] Even earlier, a March 16 summary of the administration's Yugoslavia policy for a principals' meeting on Bosnia and Croatia stated that one of the issues facing the administration was that "advocates of a lifting of the arms embargo are beginning to sit in both houses of the Congress."[39] The administration was already aware of the dangers of the Congressional bills and actively working on ways to improve its policy to maintain control of the situation. While the Srebrenica Genocide heightened the stakes, it was

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[36] Alexander Vershbow, "Bosnia Strategy Paper," in *Declassified Documents Concerning Genocide in the Former Yugoslavia*, 2013-0656-M, Clinton Digital Library, July 12, 1995, 281, https://clinton.presidentiallibraries.us/items/show/101193.

[37] Jim Pardew, "Gorazde," in *Declassified Documents Concerning Genocide in the Former Yugoslavia*, 2013-0656-M, Clinton Digital Library, July 17, 1995, 234, https://clinton.presidentiallibraries.us/items/show/101193.

[38] Alexander Vershbow, "Bosnia Endgame Strategy," in *Declassified Documents Concerning Genocide in the Former Yugoslavia*, 2013-0656-M, Clinton Digital Library, July 10, 1995, 97, https://clinton.presidentiallibraries.us/items/show/101193.

[39] "Principals Committee Meeting on Bosnia and Croatia," in *Bosnia/Croatia - PC/DC Packages*, 2012-0798-F, Clinton Digital Library, Mar. 16, 1995, 13, https://clinton.presidentiallibraries.us/items/show/72446.

also just another event to which the administration had to react to keep control of its foreign policy.

In addition, this argument does not clarify why the administration chose air strikes as its response to the Srebrenica Genocide. As shown in the documents above, the administration's plan to stop the lift bill was quite vague—the memoranda discuss needing to "stabilize the situation,"[40] push back against the Bosnian Serbs,[41] and get UNPROFOR to "show some resolve immediately."[42] As a result, the administration had a variety of options for responding to the Srebrenica Genocide and meeting its goal of avoiding the lifting of the arms embargo. Pushing for air strikes, after the chaos of UNPROFOR soldiers being taken hostage by the Bosnian Serb army in May of 1995 in response to air strikes, is not an obvious choice by any means. In fact, this choice contradicts the primary reason supporters of the Congressional pressure argument give for the bills putting pressure on the administration: opposition to anything that would force UNPROFOR to withdraw. States with troops in UNPROFOR, particularly France and Great Britain, even before the air strike hostage crisis mentioned above, opposed using air strikes for fear of these strikes hurting their own troops.[43] Pushing for air strikes that clearly would lead to the withdrawal of UNPROFOR and the U.S. troop commitment is completely opposed to the Congressional pressure argument.

Election Pressure

Similarly, the upcoming election argument does not fully explain the administration's policy change after the Srebrenica Genocide. Supporters argue that the election was a constant concern for the Clinton Administration, and the Srebrenica Genocide showed to voters the

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[40] Drew, "Memorandum for Anthony Lake," 237.
[41] Vershbow, "Bosnia Strategy Paper," 281.
[42] Pardew, "Gorazde," 234.
[43] Trenta, "Clinton," 63.

administration's inability to cope in foreign policy matters, as well as shocked them greatly; as a result, the administration had to firmly respond to the genocide or risk losing the election.[44] Contemporaries certainly viewed the election as an important pressure. In a New York Times article published on August 19, 1995, Stephen Engelberg explained that "The nightmare scenario for the White House, several officials said, would be for the United Nations force to stagger through another winter and then ask for American help with its withdrawal next spring, just as the presidential campaign is heating up."[45]

However, as is clear from the quote above, the election pressure felt by the administration was more general than just the Srebrenica Genocide. The administration was not worried about the bad press from the Srebrenica Genocide, but about having to intervene in Bosnia during the next election year, and this pressure existed before the genocide. The case of Vershbow's Bosnia Endgame Strategy clearly illustrates this fact. Vershbow wrote this on July 10, 1995 and used the election to argue for pushing for a conclusion for the Bosnia issue in 1995. He stated:

> In the midst of the U.S. presidential election campaign, our Allies could force the decision to implement OPLAN 40104 [withdrawal of UNPROFOR troops] upon us…The flexibility needed to make critical decisions would be severely constrained by the glare of the campaign, which argues for bringing the Bosnian issue to a head this year.[46]

Furthermore, after the genocide, the upcoming election was not a major concern. As shown in the previous section, the vast majority of the policy papers were concerned with the lifting of the arms embargo. In fact, out of the fifty-three documents included in the corpus of

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[44] Barthe and David, "Foreign Policy-Making," 7; Trenta, "Clinton," 81.
[45] Stephen Engelberg, "How Events Drew U.S. into Balkans," *New York Times*, Aug. 19, 1995, https://www.nytimes.com/1995/08/19/world/how-events-drew-us-into-balkans.html.
[46] Vershbow, "Bosnia Endgame Strategy," 96.

analysis for this paper, only Vershbow's paper seriously engaged with the election as a vital pressure for changing policy.

French President Chirac

Some scholars argue that French President Chirac, who directly insulted the U.S.'s lack of control of the situation and proclaimed his choice to supply more peacekeepers, pressured the U.S. through shame. On June 14, 1995, after a visit to the U.S., Chirac stated that the "seat of leader of the free world was 'vacant,'" and, after the fall of Srebrenica, he immediately pledged one thousand troops for the protection of Goražde.[47] This comment and this action, when contrasted with the U.S.'s muddle-through policy, seem obviously influential on the Clinton Administration.

However, officials never mentioned French pressure as a reason for taking control of the Bosnian War. Instead, officials were actively working against the French with a proposal of their own. In a July 18th memo preparing President Clinton for a telephone call with Chirac, Lake explained that the French were frustrating the U.S.'s air strike plans by pushing for peacekeeper reinforcement. He suggested that "You should make the case that we do not believe the ground reinforcements would enhance the protection of Gorazde. If he insists on linking the two proposals, however, you should suggest that Shali continue to discuss options with Lanxade, but nail down support for the air campaign in any event."[48] Two days later, in another memo for another call with Chirac, who was still not supporting the plan, Lake explained that the President "should tell Chirac that we and the British are now in agreement on the idea of an ultimatum threatening massive air strikes to protect Gorazde, outline once again the elements of our

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[47] Trenta, "Clinton," 81-82.

[48] Anthony Lake, "Telephone Call with French President Chirac," in *Declassified Documents Concerning Genocide in the Former Yugoslavia*, 2013-0656-M, Clinton Digital Library, July 18, 1995, 218, https://clinton.presidentiallibraries.us/items/show/101193.

approach, and stress that we need strong French backing if the London meeting is to succeed."[49] The administration was not interested in following the French peacekeeper plan, but in pushing its own solution on the French.

National Security Advisor Anthony Lake

Many scholars point to Lake's taking charge as instrumental to the administration's policy change. In early 1995, the administration continued to be highly divided on how to approach the Bosnian War. UNPROFOR seemed to be on the verge of collapse; while some in the State Department wanted to remove UNPROFOR and act more aggressively, others at State and at the Defense Department wanted to avoid a troop commitment at all costs.[50]At this point, Ivo H. Daalder, the most well-known writer on the Lake theory, argues:

> … Anthony Lake faced a critical choice. He could accept that there was no consensus for anything beyond continuing a policy of muddling through, or he could forge a new strategy…. Having for over two years accepted the need for consensus as the basis of policy and, as a consequence, failed to move the ball forward, Lake now decided that the time had come to forge his own policy initiative.[51]

Tired of constant impasses, this theory argues, Lake took control starting in 1995 and refused to compromise, forcing a strong, direct, and targeted plan on the Bosnian War to emerge.

Lake definitely had a massive impact on Bosnian War policy, with his taking charge at the start of 1995 heavily influencing policy. He began to gather people in May of 1995, and, at a

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[49] Anthony Lake, "Telephone Call with French President Chirac," in *Declassified Documents Concerning Genocide in the Former Yugoslavia*, 2013-0656-M, Clinton Digital Library, July 20, 1995, 169, https://clinton.presidentiallibraries.us/items/show/101193.

[50] Ivo H. Daalder, "Decision to Intervene: How the War in Bosnia Ended," Brookings, Dec. 1 1995, https://www.brookings.edu/articles/decision-to-intervene-how-the-war-in-bosnia-ended/.

[51] Daalder, "Decision."

June meeting with them, decided that UNPROFOR had to be replaced with a NATO unit that could threaten the use of force.[52] Shortly afterwards, he commissioned a plan from Alexander Vershbow, who wrote up a strategy to keep Bosnia territorially intact, give the federation (Bosnian Muslim and Bosnian Croat) control of 51% of Bosnian territory, and use the threat of lifting the arms embargo and using air strikes against the Bosnian Serbs to force them to negotiate.[53] Meanwhile, Lake was pushing his more aggressive agenda with the President, refusing to allow discord. In a June 2 meeting with the principals and president on his new vision for Bosnia, he deliberately excluded Warren Christopher, who opposed the plan.[54]

All of Lake's planning and his close connection to the president came to fruition. Out of 35 post-Srebrenica documents, 10 are written by him or for him, and more involve him, such as the Principals' meetings. He was also the author of all the presidents' memos on talking points with foreign leaders and carefully managed the president's relationship with Chirac after the Genocide to force the French to support air strikes, as shown in the preceding section. Thus, Lake's taking control allowed for a realistic, useful Bosnian War policy to form over a period of several months, a policy that was ready to be implemented after the Srebrenica Genocide.

This argument begins to clarify the phenomenon pushing the administration to act, but it fails to thoroughly explain it. Two key questions come up: why did Lake decide to take charge in early 1995, and why did he gravitate so quickly to his decisions in the June meeting? The impasse had existed since the inauguration of the administration—by 1995, Lake had had almost two full years to decide that enough was enough and push a policy through. Similarly, the administration had stuck with its muddle-through policy for so long because it wanted to avoid a UNPROFOR withdrawal and more investment in the Bosnian War than was necessary. As

[52] Daalder, "Decision."
[53] Daalder, "Decision."
[54] Barthe and David, "Foreign Policy-Making," 13.

shown when discussing Congressional pressure on the administration, officials were deeply concerned about the troop commitment Clinton had made in the event of a UNPROFOR withdrawal. Why, then, did Lake so quickly decide to remove UNPROFOR?

Change on the Ground

One final argument in the literature begins to answer these questions: the change on the ground in Bosnia. With the start of the new year of 1995, the Bosnian Serb leadership decided that it would not allow the war to continue through another winter.[55] As a result, the Bosnian Serbs devised and implemented a plan that would get them to total control of Bosnia before the year was over—attacking safe areas. First they would attack Srebrenica, Zepa, and Goražde, all three of which, being in the eastern part of Bosnia, were easily accessible, then move on to Bihać in the northwest, and then, finally, to Sarajevo, the capital.[56] This massive push, supporters argue, meant that the war crimes the Bosnian Serb army was committing were much more visible and more concentrated in time when compared to previous years of the war, making U.S. inaction virtually impossible.

This argument can be combined with the one on Anthony Lake to begin to explain the Clinton Administration's action after the Srebrenica Genocide. The increasing number and visibility of war crimes starting in 1995 made the need for a more cohesive Bosnia policy clearer and clearer to Anthony Lake, who took charge and pushed that policy through. We should, though, expand this argument more broadly: developments in the ground situation since the start of the administration's tenure gradually affected officials' choices on the Bosnian War, culminating in strong action after the Srebrenica Genocide. I will discuss this argument more in

[55] Daalder, "Decision."
[56] Daalder, "Decision."

depth in the following pages, but first I wish to elaborate on one missing piece—the mechanism by which the ground situation influenced officials.

Narrative, Norms, and Doxa: A Theory

Narrative

An administration-level narrative lays the foundation for my mechanism. Gearóid Ó Tuathail, in his article on thinking and reasoning in the U.S. government about the Bosnian War, argues that framing was vital for decision-making on the war.[57] He describes that the Bosnian War could be viewed in a variety of ways depending on how officials answered basic questions (who, what, where) about the conflict, and that these different views led to different responses.[58] Officials could see the conflict as one between aggressor and victim or between equals (answering "who"), as one of aggression or as a civil war (answering "what"), and as a local or regional or global war (answering "where"), allowing them to construct radically different storylines about the same conflict.[59] These choices led to two opposed storylines in the administration—the Pentagon's "Balkan Vietnam" and the State Department's "European genocide"—resulting, consequently, in completely different response options and the impasse of the muddle-through period.[60] Narrative—the definition of the problem—constrained the choices officials could make on the Bosnian War.

Norms

The concept of norms elucidates how exactly narrative influences policy decision-making. Finnemore and Sikkink explain that norms are a "standard of appropriate behavior for actors with a given identity."[61] The U.S. identifies itself as a liberal democracy concerned with

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[57] Gearóid Ó Tuathail, "Theorizing Practical Geopolitical Reasoning: The Case of The United States' Response to The War in Bosnia," *Political Geography* 21, no. 5 (2002), https://doi.org/10.1016/S0962-6298(02)00009-4.
[58] Tuathail, "Theorizing."
[59] Tuathail, "Theorizing."
[60] Tuathail, "Theorizing."

and opposing human rights abuses around the world. As a result, if officials in the Clinton Administration defined the Bosnian War as a genocide (per the State Department's narrative, as described by Tuathail), the only appropriate behavior for the U.S. would be to intervene in the war. On the other hand, if officials saw the Bosnian War as a new Vietnam (per the Pentagon's narrative), the U.S. would be less likely to intervene, given the shame surrounding that war and the hypocrisy the U.S. showcased in Vietnam.

Doxa

We can push deeper into this mechanism. In her famous paper on the international nuclear taboo, Nina Tannenwald explains that "Norms do not determine outcomes, they shape realms of possibility."[62] This description of the power of norms as crafting a specific world of options calls directly to sociologist Pierre Bourdieu's concept of doxa. Bourdieu defines doxa as "the class of that which is taken for granted," explaining that orthodoxy and heterodoxy both exist within doxa, and are debated, but some things exist outside of doxa, and these are not even considered in debate.[63] Norms create this doxa of options, and narratives trigger these norms. With the Bosnian War, then, the Clinton Administration gradually developed a narrative about the conflict, a narrative that triggered norms about acting, norms that shaped a doxa of policy options, narrowing the responses of the Clinton Administration to the war.

Narratives and The Creation of a Doxa of Policy Options: An Argument

To conclude, then, I disagree with scholars who point to the lift bill in the Senate, the upcoming presidential election, and French President Chirac as being the major factors that pressured the Clinton Administration into changing its approach to the Bosnian War after the

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[61] Martha Finnemore and Kathryn Sikkink, "International Norm Dynamics and Political Change," *International Organization* 52, no. 4 (1998): 891, https://www.jstor.org/stable/2601361.
[62] Nina Tannenwald, "The Nuclear Taboo: The United States and the Normative Basis of Nuclear Non-Use," *International Organization* 53, no. 3 (1999): 435, https://www.jstor.org/stable/2601286.
[63] Pierre Bourdieu, *Outline of A Theory of Practice* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1995), 168.

Srebrenica Genocide. Instead, I argue that, from 1993 to 1995, the Bosnian Serbs' war crimes shaped a narrative of a war of aggression in the Clinton Administration, which in turn shaped the doxa of options available to the administration after the Srebrenica Genocide. This doxa allowed for a very limited set of options after the genocide, forcing the administration to act decisively with air strikes to protect Goražde.

Section I: 1993 and The Beginning of The Clinton Administration

Narrative: Just Another Ethnic War

At the start of the Clinton Administration, the Bosnian War narrative was that it was just another ethnic conflict with which the administration had to deal. Memoranda show the lack of salience of the Bosnian War for the administration. In a February 1, 1993 memorandum of a conversation between the Secretary of State and Vance and Owen on the Vance-Owen Peace Plan, the Secretary showcased a complete lack of interest in the war. He explained to Vance and Owen, "the Administration is only 10 days in office, it has inherited an impossible situation, and it is mid way through a policy review. We hope the negotiating process can be sustained, and we'll look for ways to help."[64] The Secretary also showed very little urgency. At the end of the meeting, he stated that he was grateful for the chance to talk and that "the Administration's policy review would go forward, and perhaps could be accelerated, but it would be a mistake to force answers to some of the ultimate questions before the policy was in place to deal with them."[65]

Furthermore, in a February 19, 1993 memorandum for Anthony Lake on his meeting with General John Shalikashvili, the only line dedicated to Bosnia is the following: "Bosnia. This should take up the bulk of the meeting. Shali will want to brief you on the status of work at

[64] "Memorandum of Conversation," in *Declassified Documents Concerning Bosnia*, 2015-0923-M, Clinton Digital Library, Feb. 1, 1993, 6, https://clinton.presidentiallibraries.us/items/show/101138.
[65] "Memorandum of Conversation," 6.

SHAPE, and solicit your views on next steps."[66] Though Bosnia was supposed to be the largest part of the meeting, only two sentences were dedicated to explaining it, and the discussion itself centered around SHAPE, NATO headquarters, not anything on the ground. This measured and bureaucratic approach to the Bosnian War clearly showcases the little interest in the conflict, emphasizing a view of the conflict as another annoying ethnic conflict the administration had to face.

In addition, the administration focused mostly on the Bosnian War's broader security implications, underscoring that the Clinton Administration's narrative of the conflict at this point was that it was just another ethnic war. In a memorandum for Lake, Jane E. Hole wrote on March 3rd that "the real 'ball' to keep an eye on in Bosnia is **an equitable and workable negotiated settlement** [emphasis in document], both for what it achieves in Bosnia and for how it enhances prospects for preventing renewed violence in Croatia and an outbreak of violence in Kosovo."[67] She added that "the more modest objective would be based on the urgent need to stop the fighting and civilian suffering, pending agreement on the future political structure of the country. It would also seek to broaden the scope of the discussion beyond Bosnia itself, to try to create stability in the former Yugoslavia."[68] Though Hole did note that the conflict should be stopped as soon as possible to help civilians, she repeatedly emphasized the importance of resolving the conflict for maintaining stability in the region of the former Yugoslavia. This concern with stability is a hallmark of approaches to ethnic conflicts that have little personal salience for the U.S.

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[66] Barry F. Lowenkron, "Memorandum for Anthony Lake," in *Declassified Documents Concerning Bosnia*, 2015-0923-M, Clinton Digital Library, Feb. 19, 1993, 8, https://clinton.presidentiallibraries.us/items/show/101138.
[67] Jane E. Hole, "Memorandum for Anthony Lake," in *Declassified Documents Concerning Bosnia*, 2015-0923-M, Clinton Digital Library, Mar. 4, 1993, 43, https://clinton.presidentiallibraries.us/items/show/101138.
[68] Hole, "Memorandum for Anthony Lake," 44.

Finally, the administration is not particularly concerned with forcing an ethical settlement. As shown in the quotes above, Hole just wanted an agreement that would stop the fighting and keep the former Yugoslavia from complete violent collapse. She did note that the agreement should be "equitable," but she also emphasized the need for the agreement to be "workable," and, as will be shown later, went on to argue for the benefits of allowing a *de facto* partition of Bosnia. Furthermore, in his conversation with Vance and Owen, cited above, the Secretary of State did mention potential pushback from Congress on the Vance-Owen Peace Plan's ethics, but didn't seem to share the concern: "Secretary Christopher said he had a question for Vance and Owen that he knew would be asked by Congress: 'Why should the US support a plan that punishes Bosnian Muslims, the victims of this war?'"[69] Christopher himself was not concerned that the VOPP is unethical; he was merely concerned that approval of the plan would be blocked by Congress and wanted to know how to respond to legislators' potential issues with the agreement. A lack of interest in an ethical settlement is another facet of approaches to irrelevant ethnic conflicts.

Doxa: All Options Open, Including Partition

As a result of this narrative of the Bosnian War as just another ethnic conflict, and the need to stabilize the region above all else, all options were on the table. The most extreme example of this wide doxa is the Hole memorandum discussed above, which, as previously mentioned, seriously considered the *de facto* partition of Bosnia. Hole described that the US in her proposal would work on a ceasefire and broader humanitarian aid, "not on an ultimate political solution, and we would not, in practice, resist the de facto extension of Belgrade and Zagreb authority to the Serbian and Croatian controlled areas."[70] She added that her plan would

[69] "Memorandum of Conversation," 4.
[70] Hole, "Memorandum for Anthony Lake," 46.

"create a de facto partition of Bosnia, establishing a de facto Muslim enclave state…along with de facto Serbian and Croatian 'ministates' with very close connections to Croatia and Serbia."[71] Given that the Bosnian War was seen as an ethnic war, the U.S. felt no need to intervene for an ethical political settlement; as long as fighting could be stopped, partitioning Bosnia was an option.

Hole, however, was not blind to potential concerns with her plan. She did explain that the solution she proposes is highly unethical, but, even in this discussion, she focused on the consequences of an unethical agreement for the U.S., not for the people affected. Hole wrote that "The 'solution' rewards ethnic cleansing and aggression, and indeed all but concedes the creation of a Greater Serbia, absorbing big chunks of Croatia and Bosnia. As such it is immoral, and likely to encourage further ethnic aggression in the Balkans and elsewhere."[72] Though Hole did call her own plan "immoral," it is clear from her next clause, on this immorality supporting ethnic aggression in general, that she was concerned about this immorality feeding into beliefs that ethnic wars would be rewarded, not about being immoral in a personal sense. This concern with immorality for stability reasons is even clearer in her discussion of other problems with her proposal later on. She noted that "even if they [the Bosnian Muslims] accepted it now, on the ground that, having been abandoned by the West, they have no choice, they will never be reconciled to the result. We will have created what former French Defense Minister Joxe rightly called 'a Gaza strip in the middle of Europe.'"[73] For Hole, who saw the Bosnian War as another ethnic conflict, the immorality of her plan was only relevant because of the way it could perpetuate the violence in the Balkans.

Section II: Pre-Srebrenica 1995

[71] Hole, "Memorandum for Anthony Lake," 46.
[72] Hole, "Memorandum for Anthony Lake," 47.
[73] Hole, "Memorandum for Anthony Lake," 47-48.

Narrative: Starting to See a War of Aggression

By the spring and summer of 1995, Clinton Administration officials had begun to identify the Bosnian Serbs as the aggressors in the Bosnian War, leading to a completely different doxa of options. By this period, officials had begun to receive strong information on the war crimes committed by the Bosnian Serbs, information that emphasized the lack of crimes committed by the Croats and Bosnian government. The most comprehensive document on war crimes from this time period is an intelligence report from the DCI Interagency Balkan Task Force titled "Bosnia: Serb Ethnic Cleansing." It concluded that "evidence—[classified]—indicates that ethnic Serb forces have carried out at least 90% of the destruction, displacement, and loss of life associated with ethnic cleansing."[74] It also indicted the top levels of the Bosnian Serba army, stating, "we lack conclusive evidence…but the systematic, widespread nature of Serb actions strongly suggests that Pale [Bosnian Serb headquarters]—and perhaps Belgrade [Serbian capital]—have exercised a carefully veiled role in the purposeful destruction and dispersal of Bosnia's non-Serb population."[75] The report thus was clear in emphasizing the Bosnian Serb army's focused and coordinated ethnic cleansing efforts.

Furthermore, the report was careful to exonerate the Bosnian Croat and Muslim armies while underscoring Bosnian Serb war crimes. It explained that "Croats and Muslims have also committed atrocities and forced other ethnic groups to flee…but the ethnic cleansing actions of the Bosnian Serbs are unrivaled in scale, intensity, and ferocity. We have no evidence that Croats or Muslims have planned or carried out calculated, large-scale ethnic cleansing."[76] The report repeated this point later on, stating that Croat and Muslim "atrocities…have consisted

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[74] Don Kerrick, "Memorandum for Anthony Lake," in *Declassified Documents Concerning Genocide in the Former Yugoslavia*, 2013-0656-M, Clinton Digital Library, Jan. 4, 1995, 59, https://clinton.presidentiallibraries.us/items/show/101193.

[75] Kerrick, "Memorandum for Anthony Lake," 59.

[76] Kerrick, "Memorandum for Anthony Lake," 59.

overwhelmingly of random, discrete—though sometimes ferocious—episodes that lack the sustained intensity, orchestration, and scale of the Bosnian Serbs' efforts."[77] The writers of this report not only argued that Bosnian Serb war crimes far outclassed Croat and Muslim actions in terms of organization and violence, but they even seemed somewhat sympathetic to the Croat and Muslim armies. They wrote that "non-Serb forces in Bosnia have not pursued sustained campaigns of ethnic cleansing as have the Bosnian Serbs, but most often have committed atrocities or forced expulsions in response to such acts perpetrated against their own ethnic group."[78] Officials thus were receiving information that the Bosnian Serbs were carefully and methodically ethnically cleansing the Bosnian population, while the Bosnian Croats and Muslims were committing these actions only sporadically and often as vengeance.

This information made a strong impact on officials, who began to approach the Bosnian War as a war of aggression with the Serbs as the clear aggressor. In a memorandum for Anthony Lake from Don Kerrick, dated January 4th, 1995, Kerrick attached the report discussed above, writing, "Attached CIA paper prepared by the Task Force on Serb ethnic cleansing is based on the [classified] briefing you received last month. Flagging it for your attention as a heads-up as it will go to the Hill where it could fuel sentiment in favor of tougher action against the Serbs."[79] Kerrick made it clear that the knowledge of the systematic ethnic cleansing perpetrated by the Serbs moved him and should move others to focus on responses that punish the Serbs.

This focus is present in the documents. The administration clearly saw the Serbs as the enemy, given that all its discussions target the Serbs. The Principals' Committee Meeting on Bosnia from March 17th noted that "since Bihac, we have backed away from attempts to bring NATO air power to bear to enforce UNSC resolutions and pressure the Bosnian Serbs to settle

[77] Kerrick, "Memorandum for Anthony Lake," 62.
[78] Kerrick, "Memorandum for Anthony Lake," 63.
[79] Kerrick, "Memorandum for Anthony Lake," 54.

on terms more favorable to the Bosnian Government."[80] The fact that the committee stated that the goal of NATO air power was to pressure the Bosnian Serbs for the Bosnian government shows the identification of the Bosnian Serbs as the villains of the war.

In addition, the administration was concerned with shipments and intelligence provided to the Bosnian Serbs and used sanctions and threats to attempt to stop this support. The DCI Interagency Balkan Task Force wrote a June 23rd paper titled "Inter-Serbian Sanctions" discussing the Serbian government's lax enforcement of bans on trade with the Bosnian Serbs despite renewed sanctions relief.[81] Shortly afterwards, on June 29th, the Secretary of Defense wrote a memorandum for the president on the utility of a demarche to demand that Milošević stop providing the Bosnian Serbs intelligence for their air defenses.[82] Then, on July 6th, Vershbow emailed Lake with options "for restoring the credibility of Deny Flight[83] operations in the face of the new threat posed by Bosnian Serb use of their integrated air defense (IAD) capabilities."[84] Across the administration, officials were obviously targeting the Bosnian Serbs, underscoring the early 1995 narrative as one of the Bosnian Serbs as the enemy.

This identification of the Bosnian Serbs as the aggressors is even clearer when looking at documents describing the Bosnian government's negative actions against UNPROFOR. In a Defense Intelligence Report on the relationship between the Bosnian government and UNPROFOR, the writers did not reproach the Bosnian government nor suggest any measures to

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[80] "Principals Committee Meeting on Bosnia and Croatia," 13.
[81] DCI Interagency Balkan Task Force, "Inter-Serbian Sanctions: Shortcomings in Serbian Enforcement Persist," in *Declassified Documents Concerning Genocide in the Former Yugoslavia*, 2013-0656-M, Clinton Digital Library, June 23, 1995, 145, https://clinton.presidentiallibraries.us/items/show/101193.
[82] Secretary of Defense, "Evaluation of Demarche to Milosevic on Terminating Serbian Assistance to Bosnian Serb Air Defenses," in *Declassified Documents Concerning Genocide in the Former Yugoslavia*, 2013-0656-M, Clinton Digital Library, June 29, 1995, 137, https://clinton.presidentiallibraries.us/items/show/101193.
[83] Deny Flight was a NATO program that was supposed to enforce the UN No-Fly Zone in Bosnian airspace but had little effectiveness.
[84] Alexander Vershbow, "NATO IMS Deny Flight Proposals," in *Declassified Documents Concerning Genocide in the Former Yugoslavia*, 2013-0656-M, Clinton Digital Library, July 6, 1995, 118, https://clinton.presidentiallibraries.us/items/show/101193.

respond to the Bosnian army's negative actions against UNPROFOR. They explained that "the Bosnian Army also continues to take active measures concerning UN troops, such as restricting their movements" but only concluded that "UN Commander in Bosnia Lt Gen Smith expressed his concerns about increasing Bosnia Army suspicions about the continued utility of the UNPROFOR presence."[85] Despite the Bosnian army blocking Canadian UNPROFOR movements in Visoko in mid June, stealing weapons from a UN Control Point in Sarajevo, and micromanaging UNPROFOR soldiers in Bihać and Goražde (all actions mentioned in the report), the writers seemed relatively unconcerned about these actions. In contrast to the Bosnian Serbs, the Bosnian government was treated almost sympathetically during this time period, showcasing a narrative of Bosnian Serbs as the enemy against the Bosnian government.

Doxa: Supporting the Bosnian Government against the Bosnian Serbs

This narrative led to a shift in the doxa of options, as exemplified by the Principals' Committee Meeting on Bosnia and Croatia held on March 17th, 1995. The committee considered four options:

> 1. Stick with the present policy: continue to support Bosnians rhetorically, continue diplomatic efforts with reduced expectations of success, focus on containment.
> 2. Shift to a policy of neutrality regarding terms of settlement and active containment of conflict; end or suspend Contact Group activities; acknowledge we cannot produce a better deal for Bosnians.
> 3. Containment of conflict and long-term quarantine of Greater Serbia, including reinforced sanctions on Belgrade for the long haul.

[85] "The BALKANS: The Bosnian Government and UNPROFOR," in *Declassified Documents Concerning Genocide in the Former Yugoslavia*, 2013-0656-M, Clinton Digital Library, July 7, 1995, 126, https://clinton.presidentiallibraries.us/items/show/101193.

4. Renewed push for military measures in support of Bosnians: withdraw UNPROFOR, multilateral lift and strike.[86]

All of these options imply support for the Bosnian government and a willingness to push for a better result for that government against the Bosnian Serbs and their supporters. Even option 2, neutrality, showcases this support by stating that neutrality would be the result of realizing that the U.S. cannot do any better for the Bosnian government. Note that, unlike in 1993 with Hole's paper, a partition of Bosnia to end the war quickly is not even considered; the doxa had shifted from all options on the table to options that would support the Bosnian government.

It is also important to note that, though air strikes were considered as early as this point, they were unorthodox. At the meeting, "none of the Deputies advocated options 3 or 4…renewed military pressure on the Serbs through lift and strike would likely lead to an Americanization of the conflict, even if pursued multilaterally."[87] Most of those present, especially the State Department, wanted to follow option 1, while others, including Defense and the Contact Group, supported option 2.[88] This doxa of options soon narrowed further though, with the Srebrenica Genocide, as we will see in the coming section.

Section III: Post-Srebrenica 1995

Narrative: Clear War of Violent Aggression and A Clear Enemy

After the Srebrenica Genocide, the administration's narrative of the Bosnian War was one of a war of violent aggression, with the Bosnian Serbs as the clear enemy. Officials were urgently fixating on the Bosnian Serbs' actions, viewing the genocide as the culmination of the Bosnian Serbs' war crime tactics. In a Deputies' Committee Meeting on Bosnia from July 11th, 1995, the deputies "agreed on the need…to halt the pattern of successful Bosnian Serb military

[86] "Principals Committee Meeting on Bosnia and Croatia," 13.
[87] "Principals Committee Meeting on Bosnia and Croatia," 15.
[88] "Principals Committee Meeting on Bosnia and Croatia," 14-15.

aggressiveness that has marked the past month."[89] Alexander Vershbow went further in his Bosnia Strategy Paper from July 12, writing, "The Bosnian Serb attack on Srebrenica is simply the most dramatic development in a pattern of increasingly aggressive Serb actions over the past few months. If we and our Allies fail to reverse this pattern, it will only encourage Serb attacks on the other enclaves and renewed strangulation of Sarajevo…"[90] Vershbow's paper is particularly important for underscoring the level of urgency felt by officials at hearing about Srebrenica. Vershbow did not simply argue for a halting of the Bosnian Serbs' advances, but a complete reversal. Though this word was corrected to "halt" later on, it shows, in combination with the Deputies' Meeting, that officials in the Clinton Administration were highly moved by the Srebrenica Genocide into a narrative of a violent war of aggression.

This narrative is clearer when compared to the treatment of the Bosnian government's anti-UNPROFOR actions, which had heightened since early 1995. In discussing the Bosnian government's ability to defend Goražde, another safe area, the DCI Interagency Balkan Task Force wrote on July 18th that "given the limited sources of weaponry available to the cut-off Gorazde defenders, government forces have recently begun seizing equipment from the Ukrainian peacekeepers deployed in the enclave."[91] Despite a "brief exchange of gunfire" and the seizing of "armored vehicles, small arms, and ammunition," the Task Force was very sympathetic to the Bosnian government, emphasizing the reason for these actions (limited weapons) and not suggesting any punitive measures.[92] Thus, the Clinton Administration after the

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[89] "Summary of Conclusions for Meeting of the NSC Deputies Committee," in *Declassified Documents Concerning Genocide in the Former Yugoslavia*, 2013-0656-M, Clinton Digital Library, July 11, 1995, 211, https://clinton.presidentiallibraries.us/items/show/101193.
[90] Vershbow, "Bosnia Strategy Paper," 281.
[91] DCI Interagency Balkan Task Force, "The Bosnian Army's Defense of Gorazde: Plans, Capabilities, and Possible Outcomes," in *Declassified Documents Concerning Genocide in the Former Yugoslavia*, 2013-0656-M, Clinton Digital Library, July 18, 1995, 193, https://clinton.presidentiallibraries.us/items/show/101193.
[92] DCI Interagency Balkan Task Force, "The Bosnian Army's Defense," 193.

Srebrenica Genocide saw the Bosnian War with strong urgency, as a war of violent aggression and ethnic cleansing perpetrated by the Bosnian Serbs.

Doxa: Immediate Action

With this narrative firmly in place, the doxa of options narrowed significantly, focusing on post-UNPROFOR withdrawal and ways to showcase immediate support for the Bosnian government. At the Deputies' Committee Meeting on Bosnia held on July 11th, mentioned above, the deputies' suggested actions were all very aggressive and targeted, including supporting France in retaking Srebrenica and working with Milošević to get more UNHCR support into Bosnia.[93] Vershbow, in his strategy paper also mentioned above, discussed options for protecting the Bosnian government in the event of UNPROFOR withdrawal. He explained that "our post-withdrawal strategy should have as its goal providing the Bosnians with sufficient military capability to survive the immediate Serb onslaught and, within a short period of time, to begin to regain territory allotted to them under the Contact Group proposal."[94] He also added that "...we would make it clear that we stand ready to **broker a political settlement and assist in its implementation** [emphasis in original], although at this stage we would probably want to set aside the Contact Group approach and devise a basis for a 'fresh start' to the negotiations."[95] Vershbow's post-withdrawal plan thus included massive military support for the Bosnians to push back against the Bosnian Serbs and continued diplomatic support for new negotiations, in addition to the Deputies' immediate plans to retake Srebrenica and get more UNHCR help in Bosnia.

Within a few days, this doxa of options narrowed further into one specific answer: the threat of air strikes to protect Goražde. The Secretary of Defense's representative at the chiefs of

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[93] "Summary of Conclusions for Meeting of the NSC Deputies Committee," 211,
[94] Vershbow, "Bosnia Strategy Paper," 283.
[95] Vershbow, "Bosnia Strategy Paper," 284.

defense meeting in London on July 16th wrote that, given the Bosnian government's weakening military position and the clear Bosnian Serb intention to attack more safe areas, "I believe our option on Gorazde represents not only the best hope for consensus but also the most realistic option to forestall disaster there."[96] The next day, Jim Pardew of the Balkan Task Force of the Defense Department wrote a detailed memo on Goražde, arguing that "UNPROFOR, and particularly the British, must make an unambiguous commitment to prevent the Serb military seizure of Gorade and to support the enclave by military force."[97] He then added, "If UNPROFOR makes a public commitment to prevent the seizure of Gorazde by force, we can then move on to realistic military options. There are many of them, starting with an air campaign that is coordinated and sustained."[98] In this report, Pardew never questioned the focus on Goražde, taking such a focus as given, and only gave potential options for military movements, though he emphasized air strikes. This is a clear example of doxa—a few days after the Srebrenica Genocide, due to the narrative of a war of ethnic cleansing and violent aggression on the part of the Bosnian Serbs, the protection of Goražde was unquestioned, and air strikes were the clear choice for this goal.

With this internal administration clarity, officials began to push allies to support their plan, refusing to take no for an answer. In a memorandum for Lake from Mary Ann Peters, dated to July 18th, on the former's meeting with British Foreign Secretary Rifkind, Vershbow wrote that Lake "should describe our military's view that we need to bring air power to bear decisively, and ask HMG's help in getting the NAC and UN on board."[99] Vershbow left no room

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[96] "Memorandum for Secretary of Defense," in *Declassified Documents Concerning Genocide in the Former Yugoslavia*, 2013-0656-M, Clinton Digital Library, July 16, 1995, 9, https://clinton.presidentiallibraries.us/items/show/101193.
[97] Pardew, "Gorazde," 234.
[98] Pardew, "Gorazde," 234.

for debate with Rifkind—instead, he presented the plan as given, and only requested support in pressuring the other elements involved in Bosnia, NATO and the UN. The next day, in a memorandum for the president on his meeting with French Prime Minister Chretien, Lake emphasized the need for air strikes, writing that a talking point should be that Clinton's military leaders "propose issuing a clear warning to Bosnian Serbs: any attack on Gorazde or Sarajevo will be met by a massive air campaign that will cripple their military capability."[100] Once again, Lake did not allow any debate, instead encouraging the president to pressure Chretein into supporting his plan. On July 20th, Lake presented the president with talking points for his meeting with German Chancellor Helmut Kohl that were almost identical to his talking points for the Chretien meeting.[101] Having a narrative, after the Srebrenica Genocide, of the Bosnian War as a violent war of aggression started by the Bosnian Serbs, the Clinton Administration's doxa of options quickly narrowed to protecting Goražde with air strikes, and there was only one thing left to do: pressure allies to fall in line.

Conclusion

The Clinton Administration didn't suddenly change its entire policy after the Srebrenica Genocide. Over the Clinton Administration's tenure, the Bosnian Serbs gradually perpetuated more and more ethnic cleansing and other major war crimes, making the administration's internal narrative of the Bosnian War shift from a random ethnic conflict to a war of violent and concentrated ethnic aggression, with the Bosnian Serbs as the enemy. As the narrative shifted, so

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[99] Mary Ann Peters, "Memorandum for Anthony Lake," in *Declassified Documents Concerning Genocide in the Former Yugoslavia*, 2013-0656-M, Clinton Digital Library, July 18, 1995, 224, https://clinton.presidentiallibraries.us/items/show/101193.

[100] Anthony Lake, "Telephone Call with French Prime Minister Chretien," in *Declassified Documents Concerning Genocide in the Former Yugoslavia*, 2013-0656-M, Clinton Digital Library, July 19, 1995, 206, https://clinton.presidentiallibraries.us/items/show/101193.

[101] Anthony Lake, "Telephone Call with German Chancellor Helmut Kohl," in *Declassified Documents Concerning Genocide in the Former Yugoslavia*, 2013-0656-M, Clinton Digital Library, July 20, 1995, 188, https://clinton.presidentiallibraries.us/items/show/101193.

too did the norms it triggered, resulting in a shift in the doxa of options—a shift in the options of which the administration conceived. While in early 1993 officials even considered the partition of Bosnia, after the Srebrenica Genocide in July 1995 only one option was within the doxa: air strikes to protect Goražde. With this developed, highly-focused narrative, the Clinton Administration was able to, in concert with European allies, end the Bosnian War with a peace agreement before the year ended.

This paper's approach to an old and frequently reworked question in the literature—why the Clinton Administration seriously intervened in Bosnia only after the Srebrenica Genocide—is a major contribution to not only the scholarly work on this question, but also to scholarly work U.S. administration foreign policy-making as a whole. Other answers to this question have focused on political mechanisms of influence, such as the relationship between Congress and the executive branch, election pressures on presidents, and international reputation. However, this paper showcases the need in the literature for a deeper exploration of the influence of psychology and heuristics on foreign policy decision-making. While the answers listed above did factor into officials' thinking in the Clinton Administration, without an understanding of the power of narrative and doxa, the reasons for this policy shift would still have been unclear. I encourage the use of these concepts of narrative and doxa, as well as other psychological and sociological theories, in the field of U.S. foreign policy analysis.

Finally, the Clinton Administration's story with the Bosnian War is not yet complete. The road to the negotiation of the Dayton Accords, the peace agreement that ended the war, has also been deeply analyzed by a variety of officials and scholars. Nevertheless, these analyses could also benefit from the perspective and theory I have used in this paper. As a result, looking at the

influence of narrative on the negotiations of the Dayton Accords could complete this portrait of the Clinton Administration and the Bosnian War.

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